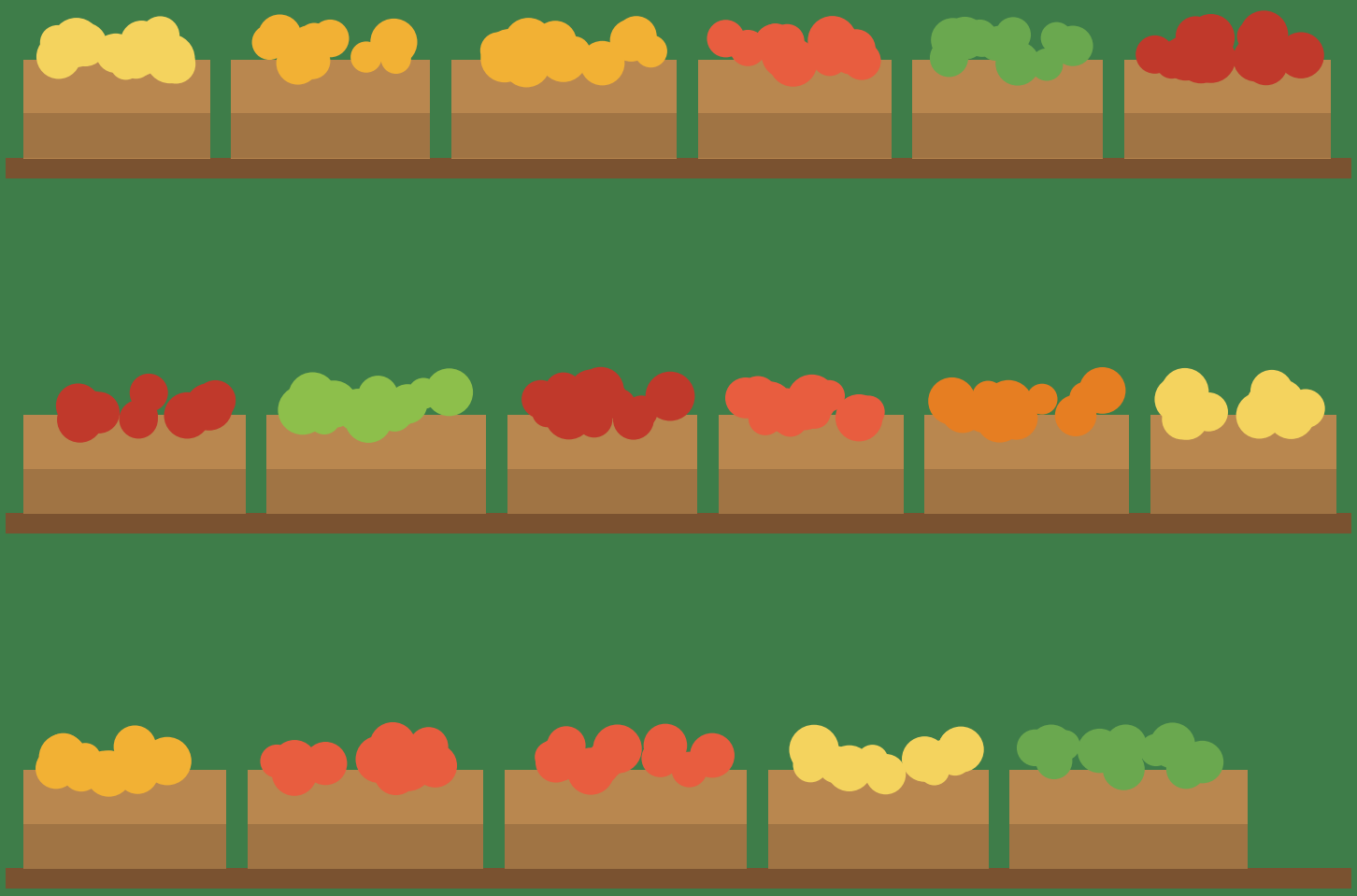


Maple Street Community Pantry

Annual Report 2026

Neighbors feeding neighbors in Columbus, Ohio, since 1994

Published Monday, February 15, 2027 | For the year January 1 to December 31, 2026

Fictional organization created for Everything AI Visual Bible. All names and figures are made up.

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WELCOME

A letter from our board chair

Dear friends,

Every year I write this letter, I promise myself I won't start with the numbers. And every year the numbers are too important to leave out. In 2026, our neighbors made 21,860 visits to the pantry, about 8% more than in 2025. Behind each visit is a family making a hard week a little easier.

This was a year of change. We moved to a client choice model in all our programs, started home delivery for neighbors who can't reach us, and replaced a freezer that failed in the hottest week of August. We did all of this with a small staff and 418 volunteers who gave nearly 20,000 hours of their time.

This report sets out what we did, what it cost, and what we learned. It also includes the recommendations from the board's annual review. As always, those recommendations are a starting point for discussion, not decisions. The board will consider each one at its spring meeting.

Thank you to every volunteer, donor, partner, and neighbor who made 2026 possible. We can't do this without you, and we wouldn't want to.

With gratitude,

Margaret Ellison
Chair, Board of Directors

WELCOME

A letter from our executive director

When I joined the pantry eleven years ago, we served about 1,200 households a year from one room in the church basement. In 2026, we served 3,412 households from our own building, a mobile pantry, and a delivery van.

Two changes stand out this year. First, client choice. Neighbors now walk through our shelves and choose their own food, as they would in a grocery store. Food waste fell, and in our survey 91% of clients said they felt respected during their visit.

Second, home delivery. Through a new contract with Franklin County, we delivered groceries every two weeks to 146 households who are homebound because of age, disability, or illness. The contract grows in 2027, and so do the responsibilities that come with it. Page 22 explains the changes this means for our volunteers.

Demand is still rising faster than our income. Food costs more, and more working families are visiting us for the first time. I'm proud of what our community did in 2026. I'm also clear that 2027 will ask more of us.

Thank you for standing with us.

Daniel Okafor
Executive Director

2026 AT A GLANCE

2026 at a glance

The year in numbers.

3,412
households served

21,860
visits to the pantry

612,400
pounds of food shared

418
volunteers

19,750
volunteer hours

146
homebound households receiving deliveries

How 2026 compares with 2025

Measure	2025	2026	Change
Households served	3,105	3,412	+10%
Visits	20,240	21,860	+8%
Pounds of food shared	571,900	612,400	+7%
Volunteers	392	418	+7%
Volunteer hours	18,600	19,750	+6%

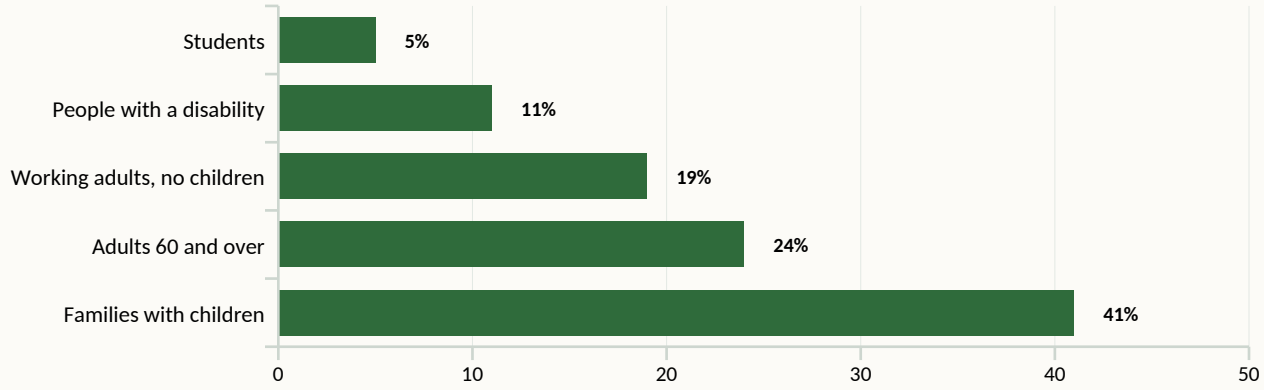
A visit is one trip to the pantry by one household. Most households visit about once a month. Pounds of food include fresh produce, which is heavy, so they are a rough measure of how much we shared.

OUR NEIGHBORS

Who we serve

Families, older adults, and working people who need a little help.

Most of our neighbors live within two miles of the pantry. Many work, often in more than one job, and visit us when a bill or a reduced shift leaves the grocery budget short.



Share of households by main category, 2026. Each household is counted once, in the category that fits it best.

First-time visitors

We welcomed 912 households for the first time in 2026. About two in five of them told us someone in the household was working full time. This is a change from five years ago, when most first-time visitors were between jobs.

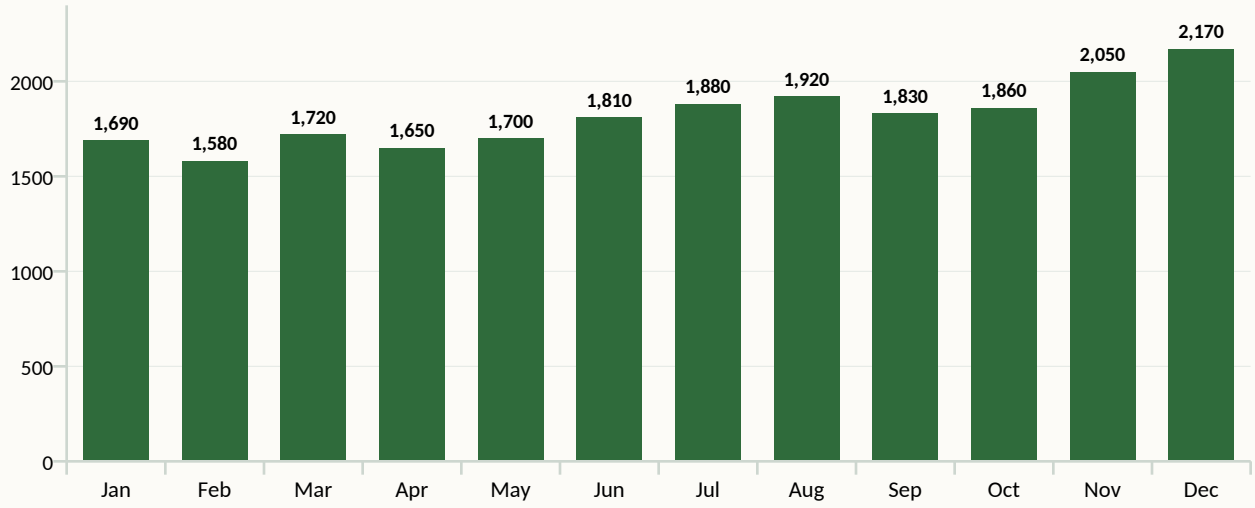
Children

Households we served included 2,986 children under 18. Our weekend backpack program, on page 13, reached 310 of them every week during the school year.

VISITS

Visits month by month

Busy summers, and the busiest winter we've had.



Visits to the pantry in each month of 2026. Total: 21,860.

Visits rise every summer, when children are home from school and don't receive school meals. They rose again in November and December, our busiest two months ever. December's 2,170 visits were 14% higher than in December 2025.

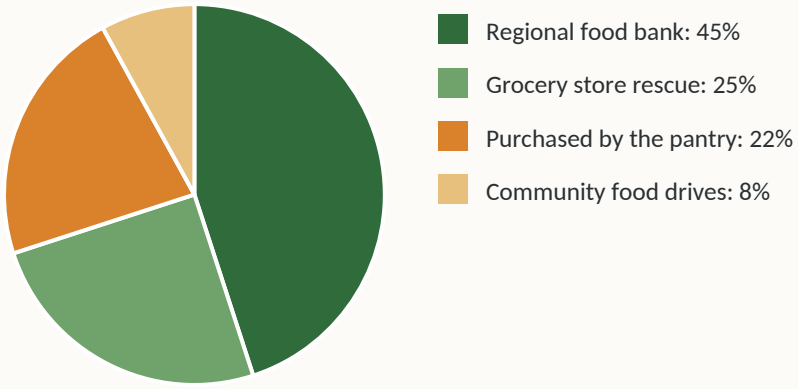
To shorten waits on the busiest days, we added a Thursday evening session from 5:00 p.m. to 7:30 p.m. in October. It now serves about 90 households a week, mostly people who work during the day.

Opening times in 2026	Hours
Tuesday	10:00 a.m. to 2:00 p.m.
Thursday	10:00 a.m. to 2:00 p.m., and 5:00 p.m. to 7:30 p.m.
Saturday	9:00 a.m. to 12:00 p.m.

FOOD

Where our food comes from

We shared 612,400 pounds of food in 2026. It came from four main sources.



Regional food bank. Our largest source, at little or no cost. The range available changes week to week.

Grocery store rescue. Volunteers collect surplus bread, produce, and dairy from six stores and two bakeries, including Funmi's Kitchen on Larkin Street, five mornings a week.

Purchased food. We buy staples the food bank can't supply reliably, such as cooking oil, rice, and baby formula. We spent US$398,200 on food in 2026, up from US$331,500 in 2025.

Food drives. Schools, churches, and workplaces collected 49,000 pounds of food for us.

FOOD

Fresh produce

More fruit and vegetables than ever before.

Fresh produce made up 38% of the food we shared in 2026, up from 31% in 2025. Neighbors ask for it more than anything else.

Most of our produce comes from the food bank and from grocery rescue. We also bought produce directly from two farms in Licking County during the summer, using a one-year grant of US$40,000.

38%
of food shared was fresh produce

232,700
pounds of fruit and vegetables

2
partner farms in summer

What we learned

- Produce needs fast handling. Anything not shared within two or three days is often lost.
- Our walk-in cooler is full on most delivery days. We can't take larger produce deliveries without more cold storage.
- Clients use more produce when they can choose it, and when we share simple recipe cards in English and Spanish.

The farm grant ends in March 2027. Whether we can keep buying from local farms depends on new funding. See the recommendations on page 26.

PROGRAMS

Choosing your own food

In March 2026, we finished moving every program to client choice. Instead of receiving a pre-packed box, neighbors walk through the shelves with a volunteer guide and choose what their household will eat.

Why we made the change

- People take what they'll use, so less food is wasted at home.
- Families can choose food that fits their diet, culture, and health needs.
- A visit is more like shopping and less like charity.

What changed

Visits take longer, about 20 minutes instead of 10. We rearranged the shelves twice and trained 60 volunteers as shopping guides. Average wait times rose in the spring, then fell back to about 25 minutes by the fall.

> **In their words**
>
> *"I can pick food my kids will actually eat. That's a big deal when money is tight." Pantry client, July 2026*

PROGRAMS

Mobile pantry and home delivery

Mobile pantry

Our mobile pantry visits three apartment communities each month, bringing fresh food to neighbors who can't easily travel. It made 36 stops in 2026 and served an average of 64 households per stop.

Home delivery

In May 2026, we began delivering groceries to homebound neighbors through a contract with Franklin County. By December, 146 households received a delivery every two weeks. Drivers and delivery volunteers carry groceries to the door and check in briefly with each neighbor.

Delivery program, May to December 2026	Number
Households enrolled by December	146
Deliveries made	1,874
Volunteer drivers and delivery helpers	38
County contract income	US$96,000

The county contract will double in 2027, to about 300 households. That growth brings new requirements for the volunteers who make deliveries, described on page 22.

PROGRAMS

Senior boxes

Once a month, we prepare a box of shelf-stable food for adults aged 60 and over, through a federal program run by the regional food bank. Each box holds about 30 pounds of food, including canned fruit and vegetables, cereal, milk, and peanut butter.

412
older adults enrolled

4,860
boxes shared in 2026

30 lb
of food in each box

Most boxes are collected at the pantry. Since May, homebound seniors have received their box with their home delivery.

Eligibility for senior boxes is set by the federal program, not by the pantry. Income limits change each year. Our staff can help people check whether they qualify.

PROGRAMS

Weekend backpacks for kids

Many children rely on school breakfast and lunch during the week. On weekends, those meals stop. Our backpack program sends children home on Friday with enough food for two breakfasts, two lunches, and snacks.

310
children each week

4
partner elementary schools

10,850
backpacks packed

Backpacks are packed every Wednesday evening by volunteer teams, many of them families and youth groups. Schools choose which children take part and send the backpacks home discreetly.

Packing nights were our most popular volunteer shift in 2026, and the one most often filled by families with children. See page 22 for how family volunteering changes in 2027.

PEOPLE

Our volunteers

418 people gave 19,750 hours. That's about ten full-time staff.

Volunteer role	Volunteers	Hours
Shopping guides and greeters	142	6,480
Warehouse and sorting	96	5,210
Grocery rescue drivers	41	2,350
Home delivery drivers and helpers	38	1,890
Backpack packing	71	2,120
Office, data entry, and events	30	1,700
Total	**418**	**19,750**

Volunteers ranged in age from 14 to 88. About one in five were under 18, most of them high school students meeting service-hour requirements or volunteering with a parent.

Our volunteer coordinator, Rosa Jimenez, trained 203 new volunteers in 2026. Every new volunteer attends a one-hour orientation that covers food safety, respect and confidentiality, and how client choice works.

PEOPLE

Volunteer stories

Earl, 88, shopping guide

"I came for one Saturday in 2009. I'm still here. My wife says it's the only place I'm always on time."

The Patel family, backpack packers

"Our kids started packing backpacks when they were 10 and 12. Now they're the ones teaching new families how to do it."

Jasmine, 17, warehouse volunteer

"I needed service hours for school. I stayed because the team in the warehouse is the best part of my week."

Ken, retired truck driver, home delivery

"Some of the people I deliver to don't see anyone else all week. The groceries matter, but so does the knock on the door."

COMMUNITY

Our partners

We work with more than 40 partner organizations. Some give food or money. Others refer neighbors to us, or offer services at the pantry.

Partner type	Examples	What they do
Food sources	Regional food bank, six grocery stores, two bakeries	Supply most of the food we share
Government	Franklin County	Funds and refers households for home delivery
Schools	Four elementary schools	Run the backpack program with us
Health	Neighborhood health clinic	Monthly blood pressure checks and nutrition advice at the pantry
Faith communities	Eleven churches, a mosque, and a synagogue	Food drives, volunteers, and donations
Businesses	Local employers and shops	Workplace food drives, volunteer days, and sponsorship

COMMUNITY

Donors and fundraising

Most of our money comes from people in our neighborhood.

In 2026, 2,840 individual donors gave to the pantry. Their gifts ranged from US$5 to US$25,000. Two in three gave less than US$100.

2,840
individual donors

US$412,300
given by individuals

US$71,800
raised at events

Events

- **Harvest Dinner** in October raised US$48,200 from 260 guests.
- **Maple Street 5K** in May raised US$17,400 from 410 runners and walkers.
- **Holiday giving tree** in local shops raised US$6,200.

Monthly giving

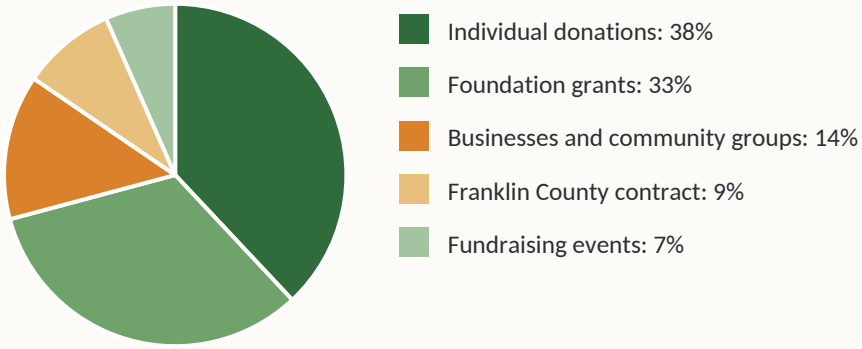
Our monthly giving program grew from 310 to 384 donors. Monthly gifts are our most reliable income, because they arrive in every month, including the quiet ones.

FINANCES

Financial summary: income

Where our money came from in 2026.

Income	Amount (US$)	Share
Individual donations	412,300	38%
Foundation grants	356,000	33%
Businesses and community groups	148,500	14%
Franklin County contract	96,000	9%
Fundraising events	71,800	7%
Total income	**1,084,600**	**100%**



In addition to the cash income above, we received donated food valued at about US$1,040,000, using the food bank's standard value per pound. Donated food isn't included in the totals on this page or the next.

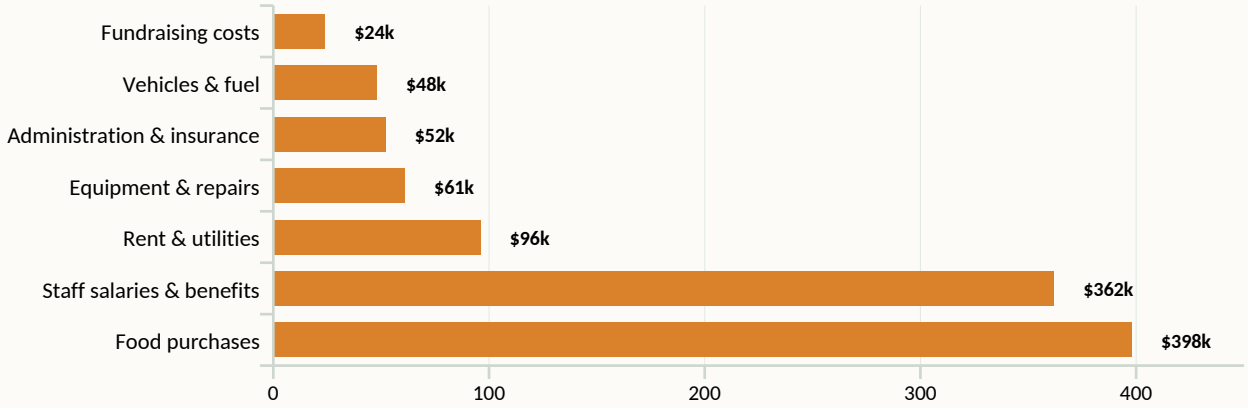
These figures are from our draft accounts. The independent audit of our 2026 accounts will be complete in April 2027. Audited figures may differ slightly.

FINANCES

Financial summary: expenses

How we spent it.

Expenses	Amount (US$)	Share
Food purchases	398,200	38%
Staff salaries and benefits	362,400	35%
Rent and utilities	96,500	9%
Equipment and repairs	61,300	6%
Administration and insurance	52,700	5%
Vehicles and fuel	48,900	5%
Fundraising costs	24,600	2%
Total expenses	**1,044,600**	**100%**



Equipment and repairs include US$28,400 to replace the walk-in freezer that failed in August. Food purchases rose 20% compared with 2025, mostly because of higher prices.

FINANCES

Reserves and financial health

Summary	Amount (US$)
Total income	1,084,600
Total expenses	1,044,600
Surplus for the year	40,000
Reserves at January 1, 2026	146,000
Reserves at December 31, 2026	186,000

Reserves are money we keep for emergencies, such as a sudden equipment failure or a gap between grants. At the end of 2026, our reserves would cover about 2.1 months of operating costs.

The board's long-standing target is three months of operating costs, about US$261,000 at 2026 spending. We are closer than a year ago, but not there yet.

Our largest grants are paid once a year, so our bank balance is lowest in late summer. In August 2026, the freezer failure came at the worst possible time. Our reserves meant we could replace it within four days without cutting any program.

OPERATIONS

Our building and warehouse

Since 2015, the pantry has rented a former hardware store at 2290 Maple Street. The building has a client shopping area at the front, a warehouse at the back, and a small office upstairs.

Space	Size	Notes
Client shopping area	2,800 sq ft	Shelves, cooler doors, and a waiting area
Warehouse	4,200 sq ft	Pallet racking, one forklift, sorting tables
Walk-in cooler	320 sq ft	Full on most delivery days
Walk-in freezer	180 sq ft	Replaced in August 2026
Loading dock	One bay	Shared with the food bank truck

Our lease runs until 2029. The landlord has agreed to install a second loading door in 2027, which will let us receive two deliveries at once.

Safety

We had no serious injuries in 2026. Two minor incidents in the warehouse, a strained back and a cut hand, led us to review lifting training and to require closed-toe shoes for every shift.

OPERATIONS

Operations update for 2027

Practical changes for clients, volunteers, and partners.

New Thursday evening hours

The Thursday evening session that started in October 2026 will continue through 2027. We'll review attendance in June.

Second loading door

Work on the second loading door is planned for the spring. During the work, deliveries may arrive at the side entrance on Elm Court. Partners will receive two weeks' notice of any change.

Volunteer requirements

Our home delivery contract with Franklin County grows in 2027, and the county's rules now apply to all of our volunteers, not only delivery drivers. Starting Monday, March 1, 2027, every volunteer, new or returning, must complete a background check before their next shift. The pantry pays for it, and it takes about a week. Volunteers must also be at least 16 years old, and at least 18 to work in the warehouse or on home delivery.

This means that volunteers aged 14 and 15, who were welcome in 2026, can no longer volunteer on their own. There is one exception: young people aged 10 to 15 may take part in the family volunteer shift, packing weekend backpacks on the first Wednesday evening of each month, as long as a parent or guardian who has completed a background check works the same shift with them. We know these changes will disappoint some of our youngest volunteers and their families. Rosa Jimenez, our volunteer coordinator, will contact everyone affected in February.

Food safety training

All volunteers who handle open food, such as produce sorting, must complete a short online food safety course. The course is free and takes about 30 minutes.

Data and privacy

We're moving client records to a new, secure system in April. Clients will be asked to confirm their details at their first visit after the move.

HONEST LOOK

Challenges in 2026

Rising demand

Visits grew 8%, but our income grew more slowly. Food costs rose faster than donations. Each visit cost us more to support in 2026 than in 2025.

The August freezer failure

On August 11, during a week of record heat, our walk-in freezer stopped working overnight. We lost about 3,200 pounds of frozen food, worth around US$6,800. Staff and volunteers moved the rest to partner freezers within six hours. The new freezer has a temperature alarm that sends a text message to two staff members.

Waiting times

The move to client choice made visits longer. On our busiest days, some neighbors waited more than an hour in the spring. Adding volunteers and the Thursday evening session brought average waits down, but Saturday mornings are still crowded.

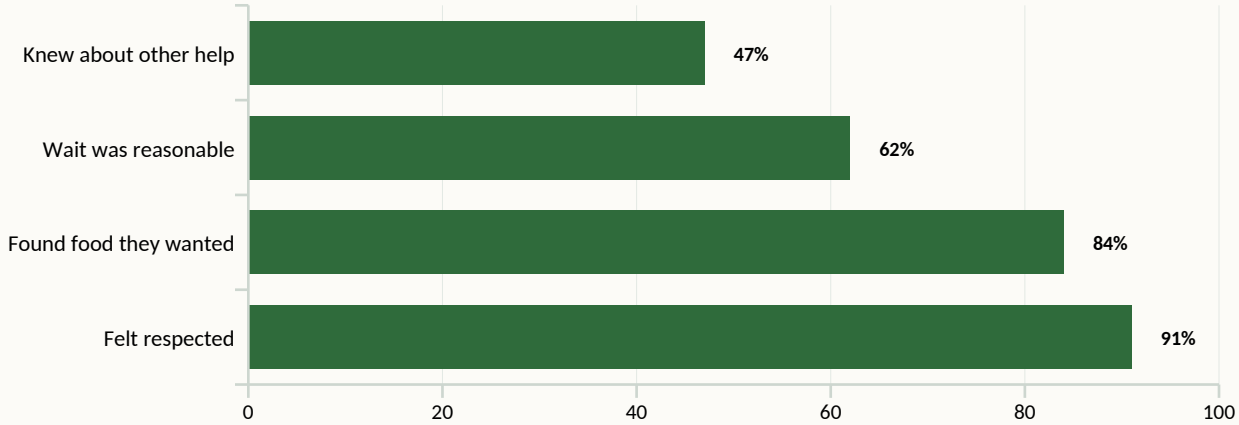
Volunteer gaps

Weekday morning shifts were hardest to fill, especially in the warehouse. Many of our regular volunteers are retired, and several stepped back in 2026 for health reasons.

LISTENING

What our clients told us

In September, 486 clients answered our anonymous survey.



Share of clients who agreed with each statement, September 2026 survey (486 responses).

Most clients said they were treated with respect and found food they wanted. Fewer than two in three said the wait was reasonable, and fewer than half knew about other help, such as utility assistance and tax preparation, that our partners offer at the pantry.

Most requested

- More fresh produce, especially fruit
- Evening or weekend hours
- Diapers and personal care items
- More halal and vegetarian options

2027

Looking ahead to 2027

Our plans for 2027 build on what worked in 2026, and on what our clients and volunteers told us.

Goal for 2027	How we'll measure it
Serve about 300 homebound households through the county contract	Households enrolled by December
Keep average waits under 30 minutes	Monthly wait-time checks
Grow monthly donors to 450	Number of monthly donors at year end
Keep fresh produce at 35% or more of food shared	Pounds of produce shared
Recruit 60 new weekday volunteers aged 18 and over	New volunteers trained

These goals depend on funding. Three foundation grants, worth about US$190,000 in total, are up for renewal in 2027. We'll know the outcome of two of them by June.

BOARD REVIEW

Recommendations from the board's review

The board's finance and programs committee reviewed the year in January 2027. These recommendations are for discussion at the board's spring meeting.

Area	Recommendation (as worded by the committee)
Fresh produce	The committee suggests that the board consider a modest increase in produce purchasing, perhaps 10 to 15 percent, if the 2027 grant applications are successful.
Opening hours	We recommend exploring, but not yet committing to, a second weekly evening session, subject to having enough volunteers aged 18 and over.
Reserves	The board may wish to review whether the reserve target of three months of operating costs is still realistic, given rising costs.
Waiting times	Staff should continue to monitor waiting times. No change to opening hours is proposed at this stage.
Reminders	A small pilot of text-message reminders for delivery days could be tested with up to 100 households before any wider use.
Cold storage	The committee would welcome a costed proposal for additional cooler space, for review later in the year. It doesn't recommend any spending on cold storage now.

None of these recommendations has been approved. The board will vote on each one separately, and some may change after discussion with staff and volunteers.

BOARD REVIEW

Risks we're watching

Risk	How likely	What we're doing
Grant renewals fall short	Possible	Applying early, and growing monthly giving
Food costs keep rising	Likely	Buying in bulk with two other pantries
Not enough adult weekday volunteers	Likely	Recruiting at workplaces and colleges
Equipment failure	Possible	Alarms on cooler and freezer, and a repair fund
County contract requirements change	Unlikely	Regular meetings with county staff

The new volunteer requirements on page 22 will reduce the number of young volunteers. The committee expects the largest effect on Saturday shopping guides and Wednesday backpack packing, where many students volunteer.

THANK YOU

Thank you

To everyone who gave food, money, time, or a kind word.

Leadership donors, US$10,000 and over

The Hartwell Family Foundation | Columbus Neighborhood Fund | Greenfield Outdoor Supply | The Okonkwo Family | Two anonymous donors

Sustaining partners, US$2,500 to US$9,999

Kestrel Ridge Software | Maple Street Methodist Church | Riverside Hall | Linden Credit Union | The Vasquez Family | Larkin Street Merchants Association

Food rescue partners

Funmi's Kitchen | Northside Grocers | Elm Row Market | Six neighborhood grocery stores | Two local farms

And all 2,840 of our individual donors.

All organizations and people named in this report are fictional.

PEOPLE

Board and staff

Board of directors	Role
Margaret Ellison	Chair
Victor Huang	Vice chair
Lena Brooks	Treasurer
Samuel Adeyemi	Secretary
Grace Whitfield	Member, programs committee
Tomás Rivera	Member, finance committee

Staff	Role
Daniel Okafor	Executive Director
Rosa Jimenez	Volunteer Coordinator
Will Barnes	Warehouse Manager
Aisha Rahman	Programs Manager
Kevin Doyle	Delivery Coordinator (from May 2026)
Two part-time warehouse assistants	

GET INVOLVED

How to help

- **Give.** Monthly gifts help most. Donate at maplestreetpantry.example/give.
- **Volunteer.** Adults 18 and over are needed for weekday mornings in the warehouse and on home delivery. Volunteers aged 16 and 17 can help in the shopping area. Families can join the monthly family volunteer shift. See page 22 for the requirements that start March 1, 2027.
- **Run a food drive.** Our most needed items are cooking oil, rice, canned fish, diapers, and personal care items.
- **Tell a neighbor.** Anyone in our service area who needs food can visit. No appointment is needed for the pantry.

Contact us

Maple Street Community Pantry
2290 Maple Street, Columbus, OH 43211
(614) 555-0132 | hello@maplestreetpantry.example
Volunteering: Rosa Jimenez, volunteer@maplestreetpantry.example